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Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Place Coverage

Kade area, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S)

(3) Segregation between Males and Females

It has often been pointed out that the joking-avoidance relationship is correlated with the incest taboo (e.g. Tanaka, 1980). But the result that, although the proximity/contact is relatively rare between opposite sexes other than spouses, it occurs significantly frequently among consanguines is contradictory to the assumption that the avoidance relation is applied to the pair for which the incestuous intercourse is probable to occur. Moreover, the fact that contact is avoided between siblings-in-law of the opposite sexes as well as between brothers and sisters cannot be explained by the incest taboo, because intercourse between siblings-in-law can never become incestuous. In fact, in San society there are several cases of polygyny with sisters, which proves that the sibling-in-law of the opposite sex is the person with whom the sexual intercourse is not inhibited. Therefore the rareness of proximity/contact between males and females among the San is not the result of the regulation based on the incest taboo; which permits one to be in proximity or in contact with probable partners for sexual intercourse and restrains the individual from being with those for whom intercourse is impossible. Rather it is due to a more inclusive principle that makes any male and female avoid being in proximity and in contact with each other.

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Segregation between males and females is most typically observed among the Mbuti Pygmy, hunters in the tropical rain forest of Zaïre. According to Ichikawa (1978), Mbuti men spend most of the time after coming back from hunting until going to bed, in the central part of the camp ('tele'), while women spend this time in front of their respective huts arranged on the circumference of the camp. Such spatial arrangement segregating men from women represents the conflict between the patrilineal band principle and the family principle; reflecting the basic structure of the Mbuti patrilocal band.

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Material Not Relevant

The analysis of organization of the residential group revealed that the sedentary camps at !Koi !kom are bilaterally organized (Tanaka et al., unpub.). Therefore, segregation between males and females within the Central Kalahari San social group, of which the formation is based on bilaterality, cannot be interpreted as the reflection of the basic structure of the patrilocal band. However, some aspects of proximity/contact among the Central Kalahari San suggests conflict between male and female principles, which is comparable with the case of the Mbuti Pygmy. Namely, males tend to be proximate with each other irrespectively of their kinship relation, while females show a conspicuous tendency to be close to consanguines of the same sex. Originally the hunting activity of San males was a solitary task, but the cooperation of several men has been required in order to butcher big game and bring the meat back to camp. The present group-hunting on horseback requires male cooperation on a larger scale than was necessary in the past. The necessity of cooperation among males might be a factor influencing the grouping of non-consanguineous males. Below two factors which cause segregation between males and females will be referred to.

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First factor is a general tendency to feel more comfortable in interactions with the same sex. The tendency to be proximate with the same sex is distinctively noted in our own culture. Various kinds of social pressure such as role differentiation in the industrial society and parental training during childhood, are at work in the tendency to be close to members of the same sex in the public place; found even in the younger generation Japanese. On the other hand, in San society men and women are not allocated 'occupations' predominantly connected with their sex, nor are women subordinate to men in an economic sense. Far from that, in terms of caloric value, women contribute more largely than men to the subsistence basis (Tanaka, 1980; Lee, 1979). Comparing play behavior between London and San children, Blurton-Jones and Konner (1973) have shown that London boys tend to play with boys rather than girls while San girls prefer boys to girls as their playmates. They have also pointed out that London girls are less attractive playmates for boys because their activity is lower than San girls. These results suggest that the social pressure encouraging children to play and contact with the same sex is not as serious in San society as it is in European societies. Therefore, the strong attraction to the same sex among adult San, suggests that such attraction is not specific to industrial societies where both economic and social differentiation according to sex are rigorously institutionalized, but rather is derived from older origins.

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